

For some, it may be easy to keep your focus on just what you need, and moving away from temptation and pressure could seem like a cop-out. For me, it just made sense. There's a freedom in finding your geographical place in the world. Whether you're a city mouse, a country mouse, or an everywhere mouse, finding a place to settle in and be content for the moment is still the very best way to save money. — **Linsey Knerl**

Finding Your Home's Value the Quick and Dirty Way

I've learned how to divine home values by looking at public records and applying the methodology used by professional appraisers. I'll show you how to do your own public-records search, and explain why online home-valuation sites may or may not get the home-value number right.

Here are some ways of judging value:

- *Tax value* (which may be based on the price paid for the house 15 years ago, the home's replacement cost, or other factors)
- *Market value* based on the sales comparable approach (that is, comparing your house to homes that are comparable to yours in geography and construction, and then adding or subtracting value based on features and amenities, similar to the approach taken in HGTV's *My House Is Worth What?*)
- *Replacement cost* less depreciation plus land value
- *Combination* of all of the above

Information can be gleaned from the following sources:

- Public records
- Aggregated public records mixed with mapping technology
- Site inspections combined with general knowledge of construction costs and market conditions

PUBLIC RECORDS

Public records are a gold mine of free information regarding tax values of individual homes as well as sales histories, privacy concerns notwithstanding. Your city or county will typically have these records, which are often accessible and searchable